



Islamic medicine

In the Middle Ages, translations of *The Canon of Medicine*, a book by Persian scholar Ibn-Sina (Avicenna), brought Greek and Arabic knowledge of medicine to the West. This illustrated page from an edition dated 1440 shows a pharmacist's shop alongside various medical practices of the time.

Healing people

In the past, the practice of healing the sick was based on traditional knowledge of herb-based remedies. The Ancient Greeks were the first to study the causes of sickness, and passed their knowledge on to Roman and Islamic physicians. The scientific study of medicine emerged again in western Europe in the 1600s, leading to ever more effective ways of diagnosing, preventing, and treating disease.

“The physician is only nature's assistant.”

Galen, Roman physician and surgeon

Alternative medicine

Alternative medicine refers to any form of healing that falls outside the “western” scientific tradition of medicine. Some forms are very old and are followed by millions of people around the world.

+ Ayurveda

Originating in ancient India, ayurveda aims for balance between mind, body, and spirit. It uses dietary adjustments, herbal remedies, and massage treatments.

+ Acupuncture

In this Chinese form of healing, fine needles are inserted into certain sites in the skin to treat a variety of conditions.

+ Homeopathy

Based on the idea of “like cures like,” homeopathy treats ailments with tiny doses of natural drugs.

Bloodletting

The process of removing blood from a patient, or bloodletting, was practiced in medicine for thousands of years. It was thought to balance the body's fluids and was believed to be a cure for most ailments. One way of taking blood was to attach leeches (blood-sucking parasitic worms) to the skin. Leeches are sometimes used today to clean wounds.



A woman attaches leeches to her arm in a woodcut from 1638.

The gauge displays the pressure.

Sphygmomanometer for measuring blood pressure, c 1883



Key events

460 BCE

Hippocrates, the Ancient Greek physician, was born. The first person to study the causes of disease, he is called the father of modern medicine.

1543

Flemish physician Andreas Vesalius published *De humani corporis fabrica* (On the Fabric of the Human Body), a work that revolutionized the understanding of human anatomy.

1628

English physician William Harvey described the circulation of blood in animals, showing that the heart pumps blood in one direction around the body.

1816

René Laennec, a French hospital doctor, invented the stethoscope—an instrument to listen to the chest of patients as an aid to their diagnosis.

Laennec's stethoscope

